

Invisible Gorilla Discussion Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-25 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-25 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	invisible-gorilla-discussion

Big idea: Attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students complete a selective-attention counting task and examine why obvious evidence can be missed.

Student Prompt

Inspect Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Counting task: students count how many times a blue card is passed while a student in a bright scarf crosses the room. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Invisible Gorilla Discussion Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	How does attention shape what counts as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: How does attention shape what counts as evidence?

Setup Checklist

- Use a short public-domain-style classroom task, or create your own with students passing a soft object while another visible change occurs.
- Tell students to focus on one countable task so the later miss is meaningful rather than random.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Counting task: students count how many times a blue card is passed while a student in a bright scarf crosses the room.
- Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/invisible-gorilla-discussion/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/invisible-gorilla-discussion/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/invisible-gorilla-discussion/visual-prompt.svg>
- Private count slip: target count, unexpected details noticed, confidence rating.
- Reveal slide with the unexpected element circled and a question about attention.

Run Sequence

1. Give students one narrow observation task, such as counting passes or repeated actions.
2. Run the short stimulus once without interruption.
3. Ask students to record the target count and anything unusual they noticed.
4. Reveal the unexpected element and compare what students missed.

5. Debrief how task, expectation, and confidence shaped what became evidence.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: How does attention shape what counts as evidence?
- Can missing evidence be a rational consequence of focusing well?
- Where might expert attention improve knowledge and where might it narrow knowledge?

Teacher Quick Script

- You were not careless; your attention was doing what the task asked it to do.
- What did the task make available as evidence, and what did it make invisible?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...